ENTERTAINMENT

HOUSE OF LAUGHS

ARGUABLY INDIA'S MOST SUCCESSFUL FAMILY DRAMEDY, ***GULLAK*** STRIKES A PERFECT BALANCE BETWEEN GOOD WRITING AND AUTHENTIC ACTING



IN THE OFTEN GRITTY, DARK landscape of India's web series world, The Viral Fever's *Gullak* [streaming on SonyLIV] is a sort of balm that uplifts both mood and soul. Currently in its third season, the show presents a heartwarming portrait of a middle-class family of four, living in a small town of North India. Over time, *Gullak* has steadily expanded its fanbase with Durgesh Singh's richly detailed, metaphor-laden writing and some topnotch performances. Each time the show's five-episode season concludes, audiences are left hankering for more of the endearing Mishra family.

A large chunk of the credit for the show's success goes to Singh. Not only does he leave audiences with plenty to dwell on, he also tickles their funny bone with clever repartee. "*Gullak* has come out from all my minute observations [of life]," he says. "To appreciate its nuances, jokes and character traits, one has to be patient." Each line has a rhythm and is intricately tied to the next. It either conveys something about the ongoing scene or offers a character study. Singh also seamlessly changes the emotional tempo. You find yourself laughing one minute, and then



ALL STAR Parambrata Chatterjee; and (right) the actor in *Aranyak*

ENTERTAINMENT

BEST OF BOTH WORLDS

Even as actor **Parambrata Chatterjee** readies his Bengali directorial venture, *Abhijaan*, for its April 15 release, the Hindi entertainment industry can't seem to get enough of him



Q. *Abhijaan*'s trailer was released last year, but it's finally going to be out this Poila Baisakh. What has the wait been like?
We could have released it after the Pujas last year but since the film is so close to my heart, I did not want to just get it over with.

Q. You were very close to Soumitra Chatterjee, on whose life *Abhijaan* is based...
Throughout this time, even after the trailer was released, it felt like through this film I could feel him around me. Now that the film is releasing, I feel like I will no longer have ownership over some aspects of Soumitra *jethu*.

Q. What has been your biggest learning through the pandemic?
If the first couple of months have